

REVIEW

Do school smartphone bans improve grades and mental health?

REFERENCES	STYLE	MADE WITH	VERIFICATION	COMPILED
10 verified	Bullets	Grounded v0.4.2	Crossref · claims	2 Sep 2026

SUMMARY

Sometimes, but not reliably. Bans reduce access to phones at school, while studies disagree about grades, bullying, belonging, and mental health.

01 Bans change phone access more consistently than student outcomes

- >> Restrictive English schools cut phone use during school by 0.67 hours a day, but students' total weekday and weekend use did not differ.¹
- >> A rapid review of five quantitative studies found a **small overall benefit** from bans, with a pooled effect of $d=0.162$.²
- >> The whole pattern is shown in Figure 1: access changes first, while academic and wellbeing results split. Read it left to right: the immediate school-time change and the later outcomes stay separate.

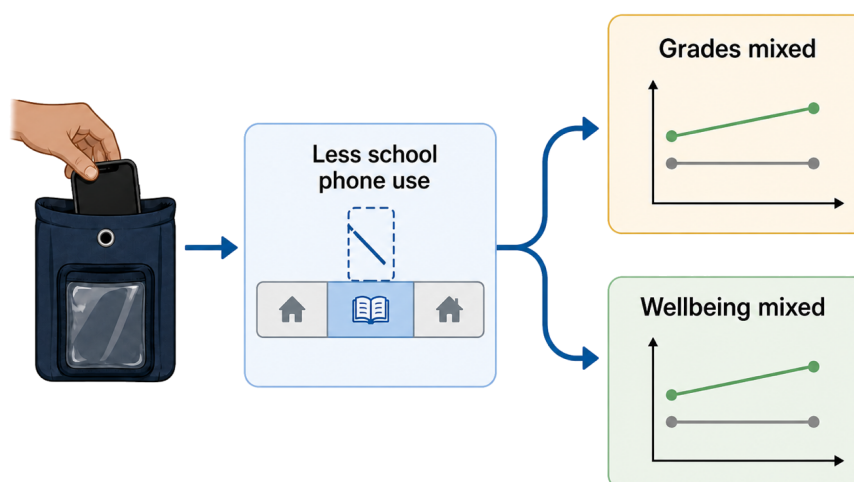


Figure 1. School-time phone use and outcomes. Restrictive English schools had lower school-time phone use but no better mental wellbeing.¹

02 Academic results range from gains to no detectable change

- >> A Spanish regional comparison linked bans in Galicia with gains equal to **0.6–0.8 years of maths learning**.³
- >> A preregistered South Australian comparison found virtually no difference in academic engagement after one month ($d=0.03$; 95% range -0.14 to 0.20).⁴
- >> In a laboratory experiment, undergraduates had higher task accuracy when their phones were out of sight.⁵ It did not test a school ban.
- >> Reviews of general smartphone use find mostly negative links with academic performance, but warn that those links are not causal.⁶

03 Mental-health and social results also conflict

- >> An adjusted South Australian analysis associated a ban with a small reduction in psychological distress ($b=-0.94$).⁷
- >> The English SMART Schools comparison found no wellbeing difference between restrictive and permissive schools (adjusted difference -0.48 ; 95% range -2.05 to 1.06).¹
- >> A Dutch comparison found no significant wellbeing or bullying differences across ban types.⁸ Full bans were also associated with weaker student–teacher connectedness.⁸
- >> During one Hungarian mobile-free day, pupils' anxiety rose while class engagement did not improve.⁹

04 The policy chain has several places to break

- >> Removing a phone can reduce one source of distraction, but it may not change total use, teaching quality, sleep, social-media habits, or what happens after school.
- >> The evidence path and its breakpoints appear in Figure 2. The dashed links mark open questions, not measured causal effects.

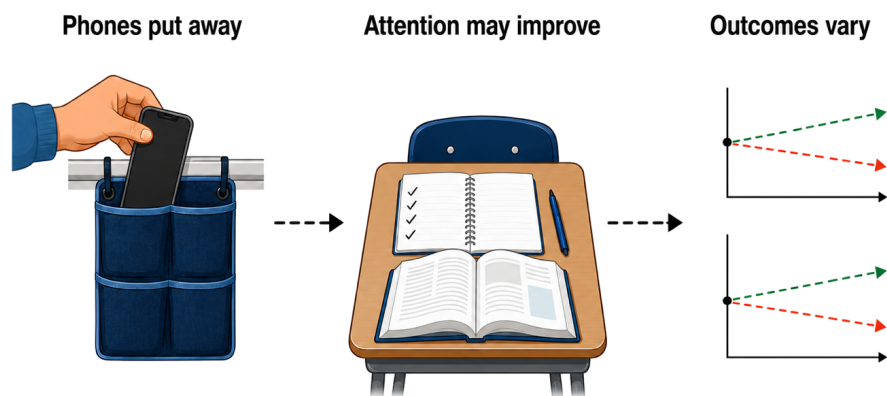


Figure 2. Policy preferences. New Zealand students and educators generally favoured school-level regulation but were less supportive of a total ban.¹⁰

- >> The most defensible conclusion is conditional: bans can help in some settings, but schools should define the outcome they want, measure implementation, and evaluate the result rather than assuming that “phones away” means “problem solved.” A useful evaluation should name success before the policy starts.

MADE WITH GROUNDED

- >> Free, open-source skill for AI assistants — ask a question, get a cited review.
- >> Every source from a live search; every DOI and retraction status checked against Crossref.
- >> Yours to run: github.com/jostelzer/grounded

References

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